one’s cousin or close relative: ‘The marriage of a young child is displeasing to the Almighty,’ he would say, ‘for the object [procreation] which is intended is still remote, and there is proximate harm.’ Nevertheless, his first wife would be Ruqaiya Begum who would long outlive Akbar and would never bear any children herself.

Meanwhile, Hindal’s servants seem not to have been impressed by their new master’s scholarly skills and his inclination for pigeon racing, for they complained to Humayun and this most erudite of Padshahs wrote his son a gentle rebuke, in the form of a poem:

Sit not idle ‘tis not the time for play
‘tis the time for arts and for work.

His precious son’s wilful refusal to learn to read must have worried Humayun to distraction. This was, after all, the Padshah who so valued books and manuscripts that he took his library with him to the battlefield. On one occasion, after his camp was plundered, he first enquired about the condition of his books. Art historian Kavita Singh writes that upon being told his library was safe, Humayun sighed and said, ‘God be praised that things which cannot be replaced are safe. As for other things, they were a small matter.’ He would have consoled himself, perhaps, with the arrival from the Safavid court of some extraordinary artists—the gold worker Wais, the bookbinder Maulana Fakhr and, finally, the painters Mir Sayyid Ali and Abd al-Samad.

A month after the death of Hindal, in the winter of 1551, Humayun sent the nine-year-old Akbar with his new entourage to take charge of his lands in Ghazni. Appointed to help Akbar was an ataliq, or guardian, Khwaja Jalal al-din Mahmud. If the milk mothers were crucial figures in a Mughal prince’s life, watching over his physical safety, the ataliqs were equally important, appointed through various stages of a prince’s childhood and early manhood. Depending on the age of the prince, these men helped him navigate the potential minefield of the Mughal nobility. They had to do this, moreover, while maintaining the delicate and sometimes conflicting balance between the prince’s best interest and the Padshah’s. According to Faruqui, the ataliq ‘was ideally a figure of fierce authority, perhaps the most important such male figure in his life’. Akbar spent most of the next few months in Ghazni as a provincial governor, while Kamran continued to defy Humayun, plundering and ravaging the countryside. After living for a while disguised as a woman in a burqa, and after decades of resistance and